Perhaps the bravery shown by security officer Noshir Sanjana says it all. On the day of the attack, he was off duty and watching TV when he heard about the terror attack. He did not even wait to ask anyone for confirmation of the news report; he jumped into his car and drove frantically, reaching the hotel at about 11.30 p.m. He dashed inside, knowing that the terrorists were still running amok, and reached the control room on the second floor, which had a security monitoring room.

It was important to man the room as the close-circuit TVs could give clues to the terrorists' whereabouts. Sanjana relayed this information continuously, enabling many to escape from the hotel.

Then he heard a sudden explosion. The terrorists had set off bombs in between the fifth and sixth floors. Several floors went up in flames and the wires of the closed-circuit cameras got damaged. Two hours past midnight, an eight-member team of the Indian Navy's elite marine commandos or MARCOS arrived at the Taj. But they needed assistance from someone who knew the layout of the building well. Sanjana, who knew the hotel plan, made a dash for the ground floor to meet them. He knew very well that in doing so, he was putting his life at risk. It did not deter him.

But he could not reach far. The terrorists saw him break into a run and rained bullets on him. He was hit on the knee and was immobilized. He crawled back to the control room and lay there the whole night, bleeding. He was rescued later, barely alive.

Another staff member, a butler named Sudharshan Thevar, the son of a chauffeur also employed by the Taj, demonstrated extraordinary courage and commitment in rescuing a Swiss couple in their seventies from the sixth floor. He remained with the couple in their room while the terrorists roamed around the corridor, trying to draw guests out of their rooms. He rolled the bar cabinet and put heavy luggage against the door to block the terrorists' entry into the room. But soon the room was filled with acrid smoke from the fire that had engulfed the floor.

Thevar broke the windows to get some fresh air. He then tied bedsheets around the couple's waists and himself to prevent them from falling, and they stepped out onto the window ledge. There was no other option to save them from suffocating. Thevar also kept a knife ready in case the terrorists broke through.

They spent hours in this way. But there was more bad news in store. A security officer informed Thevar that the fire brigade would not be able to